“I would like to live a better life”

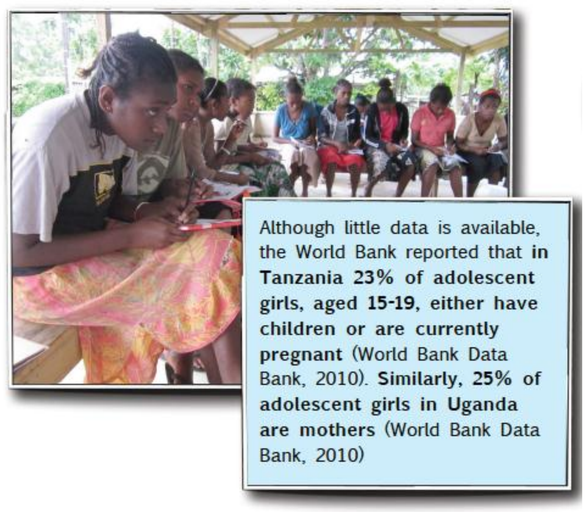
How Young Mothers in East Africa Experience Entrepreneurship Education

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Background & Research Questions

Young mothers are among the most marginalized youth in East Africa in terms of education and employment opportunities. They make up a large percentage of the students participating in youth entrepreneurship education (YEE) programs for vulnerable and disadvantaged youth in East Africa. Given their unique circumstances and heavy representation in YEE programs, the experiences of young mothers in such programs requires more careful attention.

This research seeks to answer the following questions: Who are these young mothers? What are their aspirations? What factors influence their capabilities and valued lifestyle choices?



Program Implications

Recognize pre-existing knowledge and capabilities of young mothers

Help mothers meet basic and childcare needs

Create a nurturing and supportive environment for young mothers

Provide post-training opportunities and support transitions to employment

Who Are These Young Mothers?

- Young mothers are older than non-mothers in the program, on average (21.8 versus 18.6 years).
- Responsible for more dependents in addition to their own children (2.51 versus 1.4 dependents).
- Less educated than their peers: 2.6 times more likely to have no education
- More likely to have participated in past entrepreneurship programs (23% versus 7.6%)
- Greater knowledge of employment and entrepreneurship opportunities
  - *These young mothers have more entrepreneurship experience, but for some reason, it hasn’t been sufficient. Also, entrepreneurship endeavors may be more risky for them given their heightened responsibilities.*

What are their aspirations?

Desire for a better future for themselves and their children

“I want my life to be better than right now. Today I can’t get everything I want, but at least in 10 years I want to be able to get everything I want. I want to be able to fight any problem that comes across. I want my children to study in very good schools.”

- *Entrepreneurship is a capability, or a means to a better life.*

Desire for self-employment

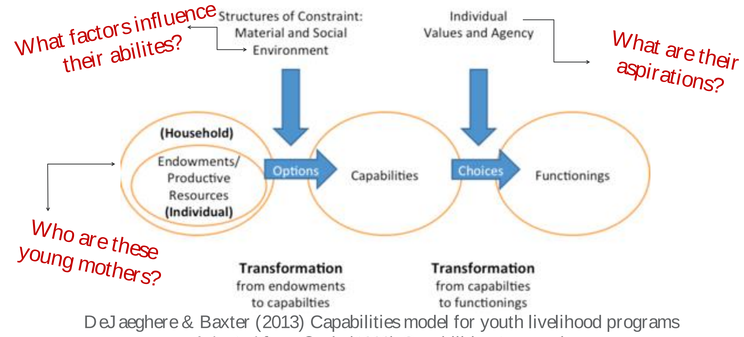
“I’ve set one of the goals to be one of the best entrepreneurs and help the community and the people around me.”

- *Here, entrepreneurship is a valued functioning or lifestyle goal as long as these mothers have agency to choose among other alternatives.*

What factors influence their capabilities and valued functionings?

- **Children & Dependents**
  - Limit participation, opportunities, choices
- **Lack of Social Supports**
  - Limits ability to meet basic needs, increases risks
- **Constraints to Employment & Self-Employment**
  - Limit options and agency to pursue lifestyles of their choosing
- **Heightened Sense of Empowerment**
  - Motherhood can be empowering, a source of strength & determination

Capabilities Approach



DeJaeghere & Baxter (2013) Capabilities model for youth livelihood programs
Adapted from Sen’s (1999) Capabilities Approach



Selected References

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